ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Mental Health and Stress: Coping Skills That Actually Help

Understand stress, spot warning signs and know when to ask for help

HEALTH & WELLBEING

Health & Wellbeing

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

First year brings new academic pressure, financial strain and social change at once. This pack explains the stress response, distinguishes normal pressure from warning signs, teaches practical coping skills and sets out how and where to seek help.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the stress response and differentiate acute from chronic stress.
- Recognise warning signs that need professional support.
- Apply evidence-based coping strategies for study and daily life.
- Know where to seek help on and off campus.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What stress is doing

Stress is a physiological response to demand. It is useful in short bursts and harmful when unrelieved.

- Acute stress sharpens attention briefly; chronic stress impairs memory, sleep and immunity.
- Common signs: persistent worry, irritability, poor concentration, changes in sleep and appetite.
- Burnout combines exhaustion, cynicism and reduced effectiveness.
- Some stress is normal; being unable to function is not a character flaw.
- Substance use may feel like relief but worsens anxiety and sleep.
- Naming what you feel reduces its intensity and helps you act.

Coping that works

Choose strategies that address the cause and regulate the body.

- Break overwhelming work into the next single action.
- Use slow breathing for two minutes to reduce acute arousal.
- Protect sleep, meals and movement even during exams.
- Schedule worry time rather than worrying all day.
- Talk to one trusted person weekly.
- Reduce comparison with social media; other people's highlights are edited.

> **When to seek help**
> Seek professional support if low mood lasts more than two weeks, if you cannot attend classes, or if you have thoughts of harming yourself. This is a medical issue, not weakness.

Getting support

Help exists, and using it early makes a difference.

- Campus counselling unit or guidance office.
- University health centre for assessment and referral.
- A trusted lecturer, level adviser or chaplain.
- National mental-health helplines and teaching-hospital services.
- A trusted friend or family member who can accompany you.
- In an emergency, go to the nearest hospital or call emergency services.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Distinguish acute from chronic stress.

Answer: Acute stress is short-lived and can improve performance. Chronic stress persists, exhausting resources and impairing health and cognition.

2. Name three warning signs that warrant professional support.

Answer: Persistent low mood for over two weeks, inability to function academically, and thoughts of self-harm.

3. Why is sleep protective for mental health?

Answer: Sleep supports emotional regulation, memory consolidation and stress-hormone balance.

4. Give one practical way to reduce overwhelm.

Answer: Identify the next single action and do only that, rather than planning the entire semester at once.

5. What should you do if a friend discloses thoughts of self-harm?

Answer: Take it seriously, stay with them, encourage immediate professional help and accompany them to a health facility or call emergency services.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write your three main stressors this semester.
- [ ] Learn and practise a two-minute breathing exercise.
- [ ] Set a consistent sleep and wake time for two weeks.
- [ ] Identify one trusted person you can talk to weekly.
- [ ] Save the campus counselling and health-centre contacts.
- [ ] Schedule one recovery activity each week.
- [ ] Check in on a coursemate who seems withdrawn.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: